EDITOR'S DESK · 01

Your paper was rejected without review.

No reviewer saw it. A short letter, no reports, nothing to revise against.

In 2007 an AMR editor wrote down the ten reasons it happens.

THE TEN REASONS · 1–5

Why a paper is not sent out for review

1 Reviews of the literature, “many of these papers resemble literature review chapters from dissertations”

2 Practitioner papers: the audience is the research community

3 Introductions for the uninformed, not an outlet for synopses of great thinkers

4 No organisational relevance, individual behaviour with no organisational context

5 Targeted at another discipline, economics, accounting, finance, literary studies

THE TEN REASONS · 6–10

… and the other five

6 Replica of already published work

7 Uninvited resubmissions, a decline after review is not another step

8 Empirical research, AMR does not publish it

9 Guideline violations, “poor presentation is sufficient reason for rejection”

10 No theory, a collection of thoughts, “however elegantly strung together”

THE VOCABULARY

What the editorial is actually talking about

Desk rejection

A manuscript declined by the editor before any reviewer sees it. No reports, nothing to revise against, which is why it is so hard to learn from.

Mission and scope

Every journal publishes a statement of what it exists to print. Nine of Kilduff's ten reasons are breaches of AMR's, not judgements of quality.

Theoretical contribution

Kilduff's tenth reason. He explicitly refuses to define it narrowly, naming three traditions in which it can be made, Kuhnian, critical realist, Lakatosian.

Uninvited resubmission

Sending back a paper already declined after review. Not a stage in the process, and treated as a breach.

NOW COUNT THEM

Nine of the ten are about fit.

Only the tenth touches the intellectual content, and even that is about a category, not a judgement of quality.

Not one reason on the list is: your idea isn't good enough.

WHAT THAT MEANS

The letter feels like a verdict on your thinking. It is usually a statement about a boundary.

A boundary you did not know was there, published in a document you had not read.

The habit this editorial teaches is simple and almost nobody has it: read your target journal's own version of this page BEFORE you write, not after you are rejected.

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Parents of identical twins are keenly aware of the differences between these apparently matched youngsters.

Kilduff (2007), on authors who are surprised to be told their work has already been published

SOURCES

Kilduff, M. (2007). Editor's comments: The top ten reasons why your paper might not be sent out for review. Academy of Management Review, 32(3), 700–702.

Kilduff, M. (2006). Editor's comments: Publishing theory. Academy of Management Review, 31(2), 252–255.

Brief, A. P. (2003). Editor's comments: AMR, The often misunderstood journal. Academy of Management Review, 28(1), 7–8.

An honest limit: this is one journal, and an unusual one, AMR publishes no empirical work at all, so reason eight is specific to it. Read it as proof that journals have boundaries and publish them, not as a universal checklist.

THE QUESTION

Have you had a desk rejection? What did the letter actually say, and what did you assume it meant?

Saturday: the other way work disappears. Not papers that never reach a reviewer, papers that pass review, get published, are entirely correct, and are never read again.

Tell me in the comments